How regulatory norms on Open Science meet epistemological and ethical challenges in sharing qualitative interview data

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Agenda

1) Epistemology
2) Sharing data- why do it
3) Difficulties in sharing data
4) Relevant for sharing
5) ReDemOs – follow our work

Mainstream OS practices are fundamentally connected to positivist epistemologies

*"…(the OS) standards describe what openness means across the scientific process so that research can be **reproduced and evaluated**. Reproducibility increases confidence in results…"*

"In the present culture, null results are published less frequently than statistically significant results and are, therefore, more likely inaccessible and lost in the "file drawer"

(Nosek et al., 2015, p 1422-23)

What problems do mainstream Open Science practices try to solve?

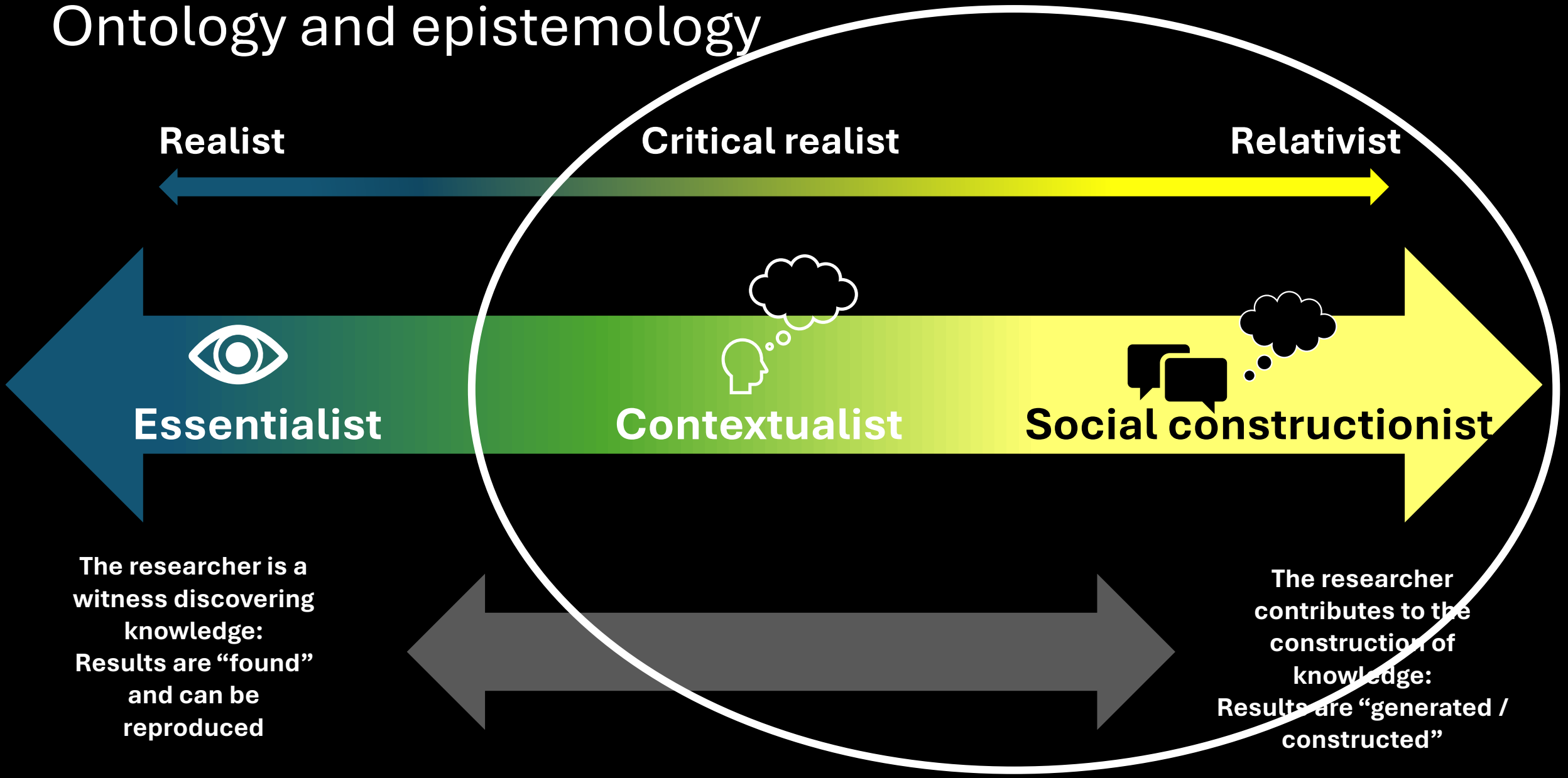
Verification and reproducibility: Checking data, avoid cheating

Any researcher should find the same results

Nosek, B. A., Alter, G., Banks, G. C., Borsboom, D., Bowman, S. D., Breckler, S. J. et al. (2015). Promoting an open research culture. Science, 348(6242), 1422-1425.

Wiggins, B. J., & Christopherson, C. D. (2019). The replication crisis in psychology: An overview for theoretical and philosophical psychology. Journal of Theoretical and Philosophical Psychology, 39(4), 202.

Ontology and epistemology



Willig (2021), kap 15, s 210; Braun, Clarke & Hayfield (2024). Thematic analysis. In J. A. Smith (Ed), Qualitative psychology – a practical guide to research methods, chap. 8, pp 168-196

The problems mainstream Open science practices (sharing data) are aimed to solve, are not relevant to qualitative research

Verification and reproducibility

- Researcher-independent results
- Others may check the correctness of the research
- Objective researcher

Understanding, context-dependent

- Researcher-dependent results: The background and positioning of the researcher matter and should be *made explicit*
- Subjectivity is unavoidable and a value

Nelson, N. C., Ichikawa, K., Chung, J., & Malik, M. M. (2021). Mapping the discursive dimensions of the reproducibility crisis: A mixed methods analysis. PLoS One, 16(7), e0254090.
Wiggins, B. J., & Christopherson, C. D. (2019). The replication crisis in psychology: An overview for theoretical and philosophical psychology. Journal of Theoretical and Philosophical Psychology, 39(4), 202.

«Aside from important ethical concerns, the idea of sharing qualitative data in order to enable replication is conceptually at odds with the underpinnings of most qualitative methodologies, which highlight the importance of the unique interpretative function of the researcher» (Lamb, et al., 2024, p. 659)

Lamb, D., Russell, A., Morant, N., & Stevenson, F. (2024). The challenges of open data sharing for qualitative researchers. *Journal of health psychology*, *29*(7), 659-664.

Arguments as to why do it?

- More people should use the same data
- Transparency?
- Possible to share at different levels

https://erezlife.com/5-things-group-interview

Jones, K., Alexander, S. M., Bennett, N., Bishop, L., Budden, A., Cox, M., ... & Winslow, D. (2018). Qualitative data sharing and re-use for socio-environmental systems research: A synthesis of opportunities, challenges, resources and approaches. SESYNC White Paper.

Chauvette, A., Schick-Makaroff, K., & Molzahn, A. E. (2019). Oper data in qualitative research. *International journal of qualitative methods*, *18*, 1609406918823863.

Sharing data - things to consider

- Why?

- Ethics
  - Permits
  - Anonymity
  - Degree of sensitivity

Confidentiality and privacy of research data - University of Inland Norway

Difficulties in sharing data

DuBois, J. M., Strait, M., & Walsh, H. (2018). Is it time to share qualitative research data? *Qualitative Psychology, 5*(3), 380–393. https://doi.org/10.1037/qup0000076

Chauvette, A., Schick-Makaroff, K., & Molzahn, A. E. (2019). Open data in qualitative research. *International journal of qualitative methods*, *18*, 1609406918823863.

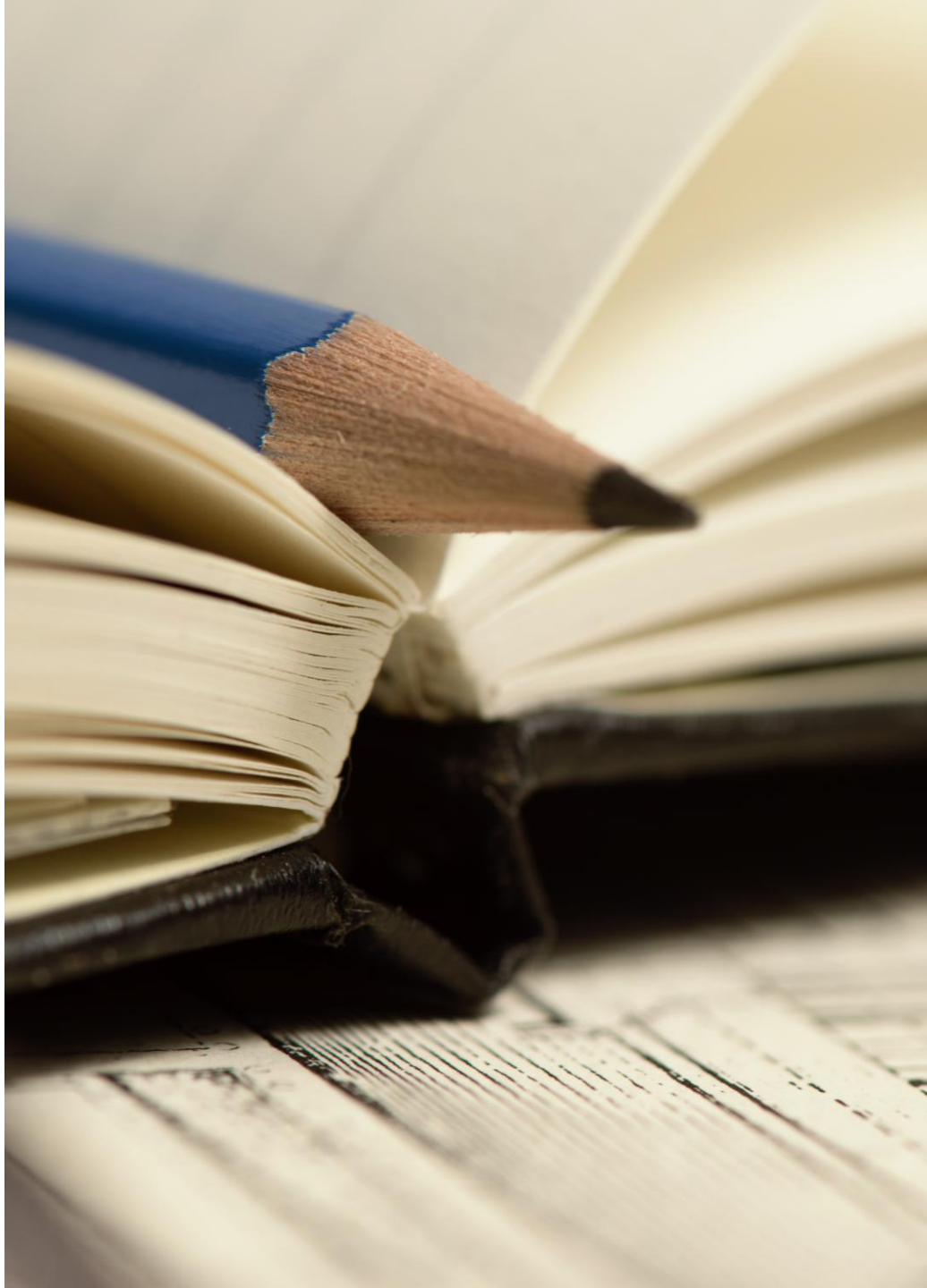
Contextual understanding

- How to add context to make it meaningful for the new sets of researchers

- Very time consuming
    - Case context
    - Methodology

Analytical starting point

- Co-construction of knowledge
- A weaker starting point for analysis



Risks to participants

- Our responsibility

- Power element/ hierarchical structures

Relevant for sharing data

Less problematic

- Open-ended survey questions
  - If the researcher has context knowledge + topic knowledge

- E.g. Ebrahimi et al., 2025

Ebrahimi, O. V., Sandbakken, E. M., Moss, S. M., Johnson, S. U., Hoffart, A., Bauermeister, S., ... & Leonardsen, E. H. (2025). Modifiable risk factors of vaccine hesitancy: insights from a mixed methods multiple population study combining machine learning and thematic analysis during the COVID-19 pandemic. *BMC medicine*, *23*(1), 155.

Social justice makes it worth it

- E.g. war situation
- Have to be very mindful, as may be very vulnerable

«Engaging participants in the archiving process is a feasible practice that is important and empowering for trauma surviors» (Campbell et al., 2023).

Campbell, R., Goodman-Williams, R., Engleton, J., Javorka, M., & Gregory, K. (2023). Open science and data sharing in trauma research: Developing a trauma-informed protocol for archiving sensitive qualitative data. *Psychological trauma: theory, research, practice, and policy*, *15*(5), 819.

The historical value of data

- E.g. 22 July

- Some events so crucial in our history: Makes it important to cater for extensive use

Moss, S. M., Hauge, M. I., Blix, I., & Heir, T. (2022). “I could have been dead”: Counterfactual thinking and posttraumatic stress disorder in individuals directly exposed to the 2011 Oslo bombing. *Traumatology*, *28*(4), 480.

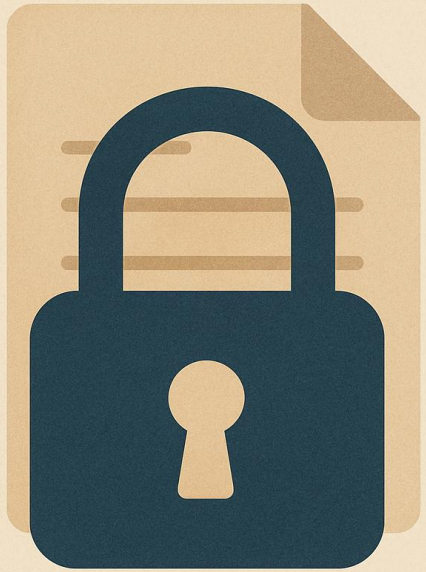
More stories to be told

- Various reasons one cannot use all the data oneself

- Need to consider: Will others manage to use these data in good ways?

Closing remarks

- Not the same epistemological reasons for sharing data in most qualitative research
- Must consider very carefully in each specific case
- Most important: Must not end up sharing in contexts where you should not
- Analysis based on shared data: often second best
  - Certain data work better for such sharing than others



ReDemOS

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Rethinking the Democratisation of Knowledge Production

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